DEPARTMENT 1 · DEVELOPMENT AND IT · PROFESSION 6

Automation expert

Profession 6 of 10 in Development and IT.

What the profession means

An automation expert designs and runs workflows that move data and trigger actions between business tools, using platforms such as n8n, Make, Zapier or custom scripts. They look at a process end to end and remove the manual steps.

What professionals do every day

Maps the process, chooses the tool, builds and tests the workflow, adds error alerts and approval steps, documents it and maintains it as the business changes.

Why businesses hire them, and what problems they solve

Manual copy-paste between systems costs time and causes errors. An automation expert connects the systems so the data is correct and the team's time goes to work that needs judgement.

- Copying leads from forms into spreadsheets and CRMs by hand.
- Reports assembled manually every week.
- Missed follow-ups.

Skills you need

- Process mapping and choosing the right trigger.
- Triggers, actions, filters, data mapping.
- Error handling, retries and alerts.
- Credentials and security.
- Documentation and handover.

Tools (free and paid)

Tool	What it is for	Free option	Paid option	Official link (not checked live)
n8n	Node-based workflows, self-hostable	Self-hosted free	Cloud plans	n8n.io
Make	Visual scenarios	Free tier	Paid plans	www.make.com
Zapier	Simple linear automations	Free tier	Paid plans	zapier.com
Google Sheets	Data store for many flows	Free	Paid Workspace plans	sheets.google.com

Learning sequence: beginner, intermediate, advanced

Level	What you can do when you finish
Beginner	Connect a form to a spreadsheet and send a confirmation.

Intermediate	Route leads by source with an alert.
Advanced	Weekly report generated and sent automatically.

Projects by level

- **Beginner:** Lead capture to CRM with follow-up.
- **Intermediate:** Invoice reminders with approval.
- **Advanced:** Monthly business dashboard feed.

Client-ready portfolio project

A lead-to-follow-up automation for a fictional clinic, with an approval step, error alerts, a test log and a one-page handover.

Worked example

Worked example. Form submitted, lead row added, a message sent after an approval, and an alert if any step fails. Each step is tested with one real-looking record before it is switched on.

Assignment with full solution

ASSIGNMENT

Lead automation with an approval step

Business problem: A clinic wants every enquiry saved, answered within an hour, and followed up once. Nothing should be sent to a patient without a staff check.

Steps

1. Map the process on paper: trigger, save, draft reply, approval, send, follow-up.
2. Build the flow in n8n or Make with a test form.
3. Add an error alert to a staff channel.
4. Test with three records: a complete one, one with a missing phone number, and one duplicate.
5. Write the handover: what runs, what it costs, and how to pause it.

Expected output: A working flow, three test results and a handover page.

SOLUTION (ANSWER KEY)

The approval step is the safety net: no message leaves without a person. The missing-phone case must fail visibly, not silently. Duplicate detection prevents a patient receiving two replies. The n8n guide in the AI tools series shows a complete Gmail example with the same structure.

Common mistakes

- Switching on an automation before testing with sample data.
- No error alerts, so failures stay hidden.
- Hard-coding secrets into the workflow.

- No handover, so nobody can maintain it later.

Freelancing opportunities

- Automation retainers for small businesses.
- Process audits and automation builds.
- Freelance briefs for 'automation', 'Zapier', 'Make', 'n8n'.

Learning resources

LEARNING RESOURCES (VERIFY BEFORE USE)

- n8n documentation
- Make help centre
- Zapier help centre

Part of **Master Freelancing: AI and Automation**. Back to the chapter list on skillnavora.in · Open the full textbook. Official links in this chapter were not checked live; confirm before relying on them.